

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

64 DAYS IN CHICAGO

The story of Operation Midway Blitz, a mission unlike anything in recent American history



By Andrew Carter, Caroline Kubzansky, Gregory Royal Pratt and Laura Rodríguez Presa | Chicago Tribune

After 64 days, they celebrated. They gathered at one of Chicago's most beloved landmarks, in the middle of a city where they'd wrought so much fear and pain, and they celebrated. It was the second Monday in November and early in the morning, the season's first snowfall still fresh, when they parked along Monroe Street and made their way toward Millennium Park, more than 150 strong. Some carried weapons. Two of them led dogs on long leashes. Some wore the camouflaged fatigues of military battle and others dark green uniforms. They all displayed markings that made clear their status as agents with the U.S. Border Patrol, and they'd arrived to complete one final Chicago mission — for the moment — to pose for the camera. One last made-for-social-media moment. At least 100 agents, including their leader, Cmdr. Gregory Bovino, would return to Chicago six weeks later to continue a mission that President Donald Trump said hadn't "gone far enough." They would bring their cameras again. They would post their tweets. And they would argue with residents as they patrolled city and suburban streets in the days leading up to Christmas. "We're here to do a legal, ethical, moral mission," Bovino would tell the

Tribune outside a Home Depot on a cold December morning as bystanders blew whistles to warn of his whereabouts. "We're going to keep doing that." Bovino's mere presence — accompanied by his previous threat to return again in the spring and detain even more people — would renew the sense of alarm in a metropolitan area that has been demonstrably changed by the 64-day federal incursion and evoke memories of the most surreal autumn in recent local history. The tear-gassing of Chicago neighborhoods. The rousing of suburban mothers in bathrobes, drawn into streets to yell at agents and shame them. The attempted deployment of the Texas National Guard, on Trump's command, only for a federal judge to order the troops to stand down almost immediately upon their arrival in Illinois. The agents who pointed guns and other weapons at bystanders. The arrests of more than 4,500 people in a mission, the Department of Homeland Security said targeted "the worst of the worst." The reality is that most of them were people with brown skin who were at the right place — their landscaping

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Above: Federal agents detain a person while members of the community and activists protest near the 3900 block of South Kedzie Avenue in Chicago on Oct. 4. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Plans to close toxic coal ash ponds stuck in backlog

By Christiana Freitag
Chicago Tribune

ALTON, Illinois — Where the Wood and Mississippi rivers meet in southern Illinois, over a million cubic yards of toxic coal ash sit on the edge of Illinois' floodplain, threatening the waterways that surround it. The retired Wood River Power Station is home to one of 72 coal ash impoundments, or ponds, across Illinois that contain byproducts from former coal combustion plants, according to the Illinois Envi-

ronmental Protection Agency. On Black Friday, while many Americans spent the day recuperating from Thanksgiving festivities, Alton residents gathered at a public meeting to discuss the future of Wood River. "Developers) have come in and left this desolate brownfield with groundwater contamination leaching into significant bodies of water," said Toni Oplt, chair of the Metro East Green Alliance. "They have held this

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INSIDE

Bears on verge of a worst-to-first season

The Bears are closing in on what would be a giant turnaround: going from last place to first in the NFC North. And they want to capitalize on it. **Chicago Sports**

RUSSIAN STRIKES: Russia attacked Kyiv a day before talks between leaders of Ukraine and the United States. **Nation & World**

WHO WE LOST: From actors to astronauts, remembering those who departed this past year. **A+E**

New laws for 2026 touch on policing, abortion, AI

By Jeremy Gorner and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

As Illinois turns the calendar to 2026, it will bring more than fresh resolutions. It will also usher in hundreds of new state laws, statutes that will quietly reshape daily life from grocery store checkout lines and police departments to college classrooms, hospital exam rooms and workplaces. Beginning Jan. 1, roughly 300 new laws will take effect, reflecting Democratic Gov. JB

Pritzker and lawmakers' priorities following debates over public safety, reproductive rights, higher education, environmental protection and the role of emerging technologies. The laws arrive as Springfield braces for another high-stakes legislative year. Lawmakers will soon return to the Capitol to negotiate a multibillion-dollar budget amid the 2026 election as Pritzker runs for a third term and many legislators' names will be on the ballot for reelection. **Turn to Laws, Page 2**

TODAY'S WEATHER



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Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 18

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